

**Medford Public Schools
Medford, Massachusetts**

Medford School Committee

April 15, 2010

Committee of the Whole

7:00 p.m.

Medford High School Library

The meeting was called to order at 7:05 p.m. in the Library at Medford High School by Vice chairperson Van der Kloot. All rose to salute the flag.

Secretary Cugno called the roll:

Members present: Ann Marie Cugno, John Falco, Sharon Guzik, William O'Keefe, George Scarpelli, and Paulette Van der Kloot. (6 present and 1 absent)

Administrators present: Superintendent Roy E. Belson; Assistant Superintendent Beverly Nelson; Headmaster Paul Krueger; Submasters Steve Mascoll and Rosemary Trainor; Director of Athletics Robert Maloney; Director of Humanities Bernadette Ricciardelli.

Additionally, there were approximately 30 interested persons in attendance.

The meeting was recorded on DVD for the record.

Vice chairperson Van der Kloot welcomed all to the discussion. She stated the purpose of the meeting: Review of Social Probation Policy and Practice.

Mr. Scarpelli made an opening statement. He does not want "to get rid of social probation but wants to review the policy."

The Vice chairperson then called upon Superintendent Belson for an opening statement (see attached). The Superintendent also referred members to applicable laws of the Commonwealth regarding policies affecting student discipline and the statutory powers and powers and duties of school committees. (see attached). The goals of tonight's meeting are to understand the policy and how it is applied; identify concerns; and have a constructive dialogue on the issue to make it better and/or rectify any problems with the policy.

Mr. O'Keefe queried the origin of the policy in the student handbook.

Headmaster Krueger made a presentation (see attached report on social probation) Dr. Krueger made the following points:

- There is a difference between the application of social probation from Drug and Alcohol offenses versus general discipline offenses.
- High school operates in "loco parentis" for students

- Headmaster listens to submasters, vocational director, teachers and others when making decisions
- The reduction of staff because of fiscal constraints makes it even more important to maintain a tight ship
- Site council unanimously approved this policy
- Unfavorable actions and behaviors by students must have consequences
- The goal is improvement of student behavior.

Vice chairperson opened floor for discussion:

Mr. Scarpelli raised the following questions:

Does the policy keep students who need help from telling because of the fear that they may get social probation?

What about “treatment”?

Have we considered community service as an alternative to social probation?

Could lesser issues receive alternative consequences?

Is sameness of punishment for all equitable in terms of impact?

Further, Mr. Scarpelli asked for a report that would categorize violations and the penalties and time frames assessed for each.

He asked, “is it working” (social probation)?

Dr. Krueger responded:

It works for many but not for all students. He also agrees that more can be done with the Drug and Alcohol policy. There should be more help with prevention and treatment.

Ms. Van der Kloot asks “How does a student get off social probation?”

Mrs. Cugno asks “Should some students be favored because of their participation in special activities?” She doesn’t want students to feel inequity and wants them to support each other.

She states, “The school is run well.”

Mr. O’Keefe concerns:

- “indefinite: length of social probation
- wants more correction rather than punishment
- wants more emphasis on treatment and prevention
- need to start in earlier grades wants “zero tolerance” for drugs and alcohol

Ms. Van der Kloot asks “whether student contracts would be an effective tool?”

Dr. Krueger: contracts could be part of the answer.

Mr. Scarpelli: Does not want to split the school apart between groups.

Gwen Blackburn:

- top students treated differently by Dr. Krueger
- social probation is unevenly administered
- participation in extra curricular is important to students
- there is a need to make exceptions to the rules.

Florie Chambers:

- concern that social probation is used too unfairly
- not against it but against the way it is applied
- sped manifestation determination wrongly applied
- students need a safe place to come
- social probation for a book loss goes to far.

Superintendent Belson advises that Ms. Chambers references are too personal to be discussed in this forum. Certain process is underway and he cannot comment on her specific case.

Mr. Falco queries social probation for lost books.

Dr. Krueger assures that due process is always used.

Athletic Director Maloney:

- parts of the policy should be discontinued
- all want a safe high school
- great kids and staff
- concern for whole child
- athletics are disproportionately impacted by social probation. MIAA rules should be the standard.
- Team captains should not be barred from future captaincy in other seasons

Issue of “captaincy” is discussed by several members and Dr. Krueger.

Dr. Krueger believes that in matters of drugs and alcohol it is essential to have a strict policy. “Would you rather attend a funeral?”

Superintendent Belson:

- likens issue to court system where the choice is between mandatory sentencing and judicial discretion

- issue is around length of time and severity of punishment as it affect certain groups
- question is whether the policy is effective. Is it a deterrent?
- Do we want to have differences among the groups? Is it equitable?
- Good discussion tonight. You are weighing all the pros and cons. Different administrators in years past had different styles and different circumstances. Medford High is well run under Dr, Krueger.

Mr. Falco: Do coaches meet with teams?

Dr. Krueger answered: yes: programs are held as well to deter abuse.

Mr. O'Keefe:

- Concern for the loss of captaincy
- Urges progressive discipline

Erin DiBenedetto:

- Respect for Mr. Maloney and Dr. Krueger
- Athletes not the only losers. Music students participate year round and students do lose out on concerts
- "where do you draw the line."
- Drug and alcohol serious
- Can we "tweak" the policy for lesser offenses
- Wants the discipline
- No one group should get special treatment

Hope Sanders:

- Spoke on her personal experiences with her three sons
- Felt her sons were badly affected by the policy of social probation
- Indefinite social probation not good advocated for a shorter time frame. Goes beyond the necessary.

Dr Krueger commented that this meeting was not an appropriate forum for evaluating the Headmaster. Discussion should stay on the topic of policy.

Teacher Candace Van Aiken spoke about the high school mural and that we should not set up an adversarial relationship between athletes and art students. We should hold all to a common standard.

Ms. Cugno commented that there is a procedure in place to ensure fairness.

Janice Martignetti supports the policy as implemented by Dr. Krueger.

Mr. Scarpelli asks for the following:

- Report from Dr. Krueger detailing the various offenses and the length of social probation applied
- What type of treatment program can be used in conjunction with or in place of social probation
- Can we move to formal contracts regarding social probation

Mr. O'Keefe asks, aren't the MIAA sanctions strict enough? Is it "double jeopardy?"

Dr. Krueger responds that the MIAA rule is a minimum standard.

Ann Reppucci, President of the High School PTO comments that she favors the current policy.

Bill Carr Jr. states that Dr. Krueger runs a tight ship and is visible. Indefinite suspension should be discontinued. It should be more specific.

Vice chairperson Van der Kloot asks the Superintendent to work on a recommendation for the committee to consider.

Superintendent will do and incorporate Mr. Scarpelli's report requested.

Superintendent comments that it has been a good meeting with a significant exchange of ideas.

Vice chairperson Van der Kloot thanks all for their valuable participation.

On the motion of Mr. Scarpelli that the administration prepare recommendations for the School Committee to consider and that the report requested by Mr. Scarpelli be incorporated. Voted 6-0-1 (absent)

Superintendent advises committee of upcoming meeting schedule and additional materials in their folders for review.

On the motion of Mr. Scarpelli voted 6-0-1 absent the meeting is adjourned at 9:40 p.m.

Respectfully submitted,

Ann Marie Cugno
Secretary